

9Marks and catholicity: one word, two meanings

9Marks, a respected and popular church ministry in the evangelical world, has set out to revive the word catholicity, and defines it in three words: churches partnering together. For a thousand years the word meant one visible communion, one faith, one Baptism, one Supper, one ordered ministry. Same word, two meanings, and the difference is not small, for one of them can be satisfied while every division in Christendom stands. This page lays the two side by side, from 9Marks' own essays and the first millennium's own documents, and points to where the full arguments live on this site.

Their definition, in their own words

In its journal's issue on catholicity, 9Marks president Jonathan Leeman defines the word in three words, churches partnering together, adding fairly that the three words take shortcuts, and his fuller essay supplies the doctrine. The local gathering, he writes there, is what we behold with the eyes of flesh, a manifestation or outpost of something we can only behold with the eyes of faith, namely, the catholic or universal church. And the basis is stated as doctrine: a right doctrine of catholicity, Leeman writes, is Protestant. It roots in a shared view of the gospel, not in a shared view of the ordinances or church structure. Mark Dever's historical essay concedes what was traded, for the word catholic, he reports, was a term used for exclusion and definition from the second or third century until the modern period, and Luther and Calvin re-weighted Vincent of Lérins' three tests, everywhere, always, and by all, keeping the always alone.

Read those quotations slowly, because everything on this page follows from them. The whole, in this definition, is invisible by definition, and the only church anyone can see is the congregation, so catholicity can only ever be a relation between congregations, and partnership is what remains. That is the low-church move performed on the word itself, the sacraments and the ministry removed from catholicity's definition before the conversation begins, and the reader should simply know it has happened.

The two meanings, side by side

The left column is from their essays. The right column is from the first millennium's own documents, whose receipts this site collects.

	9Marks	The first millennium
The question asked	How should separate gospel-preaching churches recognize and work with one another?	What has the whole Church received, and how is her visible communion kept and restored?
What catholic means	The universal gathering of all believers, beheld only by faith. Local churches are its visible outposts.	According to the whole: one visible fellowship of churches across the world, holding one faith, one Baptism, one Supper, one ordered ministry.
What can be seen	The local congregation.	The whole communion: one altar in each city, bishops known to one another by letter, councils gathered from East and West.
What it requires	Agreement on the gospel, plus partnership as occasion allows. Not a shared view of the ordinances or church structure.	The shared faith entire: creed, sacraments, ministry, morals, held everywhere, always, and by all.
Its instruments	Prayer for other churches, pulpit swaps, joint sending, speaking well of one another.	All of those, and also the synod, the letter of communion, the shared Supper, the common creed.
What division is	A standing condition to be navigated charitably.	A wound in the Body, to be healed.

The marks, side by side

The Creed's four (381)	The Reformation's three	The current nine (9Marks)
One Holy Catholic Apostolic	The word rightly preached The sacraments rightly administered Discipline exercised	Expositional preaching Gospel doctrine Conversion and evangelism Church membership Church discipline Discipleship and growth Church leadership Prayer Missions

Count the overlap. None of the Creed's four appears among the nine, and of the Reformation's three, the nine keep the preaching and the discipline and drop the sacraments. Tim Challies saw it at the very beginning, laying the nine as they then stood beside the Reformation's three in the 2004 post that introduced 9Marks to his readers: glaringly absent, then, is the emphasis on the proper administration of the sacraments. He recorded Dever's answer, that most churches still place sufficient emphasis on the sacraments, so it is not a lost mark in need of recovery, and gently disagreed. Twenty years later the nine have been revised, prayer and missions added, and the Supper still did not make the list. That is not a gotcha. It is a fact about the list, and Challies saw it first.

What the word cannot mean

The journal's own pages show the limits of the partnership meaning. Its essay on cooperation commends Ryle's counsel to keep the walls of separation as low as possible and shake hands over them as often as you can, and the counsel is warm. But the walls stay, for lowering and hand-shaking are the whole program, and another essay in the issue, explaining why a Baptist and a Presbyterian church rightly remain separate, says it in one line: it's a good thing our church isn't collapsed into theirs. The definition meets its test at the rail. Leeman opens his longest essay barred from the Supper at a Missouri Synod church, which admits only those who share its doctrine of the Supper, and then defends his own church's line, for Cheverly Baptist requires believer's baptism and does not count the christening the Presbyterian brings, so the Presbyterian stands at Cheverly's rail roughly as Leeman stood at the Lutheran one, welcome in

principle, fenced in fact. This site said of Rome's closed altar that the cost is an argument for healing the division, not for pretending it is healed, and the same sentence falls here. Even the journal's one patristic exhibit testifies the other way, for its warm study of Basil's friendship with Eusebius of Samosata stops one letter short: the same collection holds Basil's appeals to Athanasius and to Rome to knit the storm-torn East back into visible communion. Basil had the friendships. He spent them on communion. The fear underneath all this is honorable, for these writers watched Billy Graham's catholic resolve corrode a lifetime's clarity, and they chose truth over togetherness rightly. But the first millennium was not the tolerant option, and its unity bound more than the gospel, not less. And the prayer everyone in this conversation quotes decides the matter, for the oneness of John 17:21 is offered as evidence to the world, and the world does not have the eyes of faith. A unity invisible by definition cannot do the one thing the prayer says the oneness is for.

Where the arguments live

None of these arguments is carried here, because each is carried in full elsewhere on this site, and this page's only job was the two definitions.

- What the word meant and who held it: part one, the historic communions.
- Whether the first churches were low churches: part two's record.
- Where the Bible's table of contents came from: part two's canon section.
- Acts 15 and church order: part two's verses.
- The Supper: part one's presence note and objections 5 through 8.
- The fifty objections a 9Marks reader brings: part three entire.

What would change

Nothing in the nine marks needs to be given up, for every one is a recovered piece of the ancient discipline. What the first millennium would add is countable: the Creed's four marks beside the nine, so that contentment with permanent separation reads as a health problem the way absent discipline does, the Supper seated among the marks at the center of the first day of the week, and the partnerships already built treated as scaffolding for communion, the way Basil's friendships were. None of that is a small ask, and the same scale of ask stands on this site's front page, addressed to Rome and the East. The word means the whole, and the revival is near enough to it to finish the job: that they all may be one, that the world may believe (John 17:21).

Quod ubique, quod semper, quod ab omnibus.

Scripture quotations are from the King James Version unless otherwise noted.

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